Task 5 – Cybercrime Awareness

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Course: Digital Literacy

Part A – Case Study

Cybercrime Type: UPI / Online Payment Fraud

Introduction

In recent years, UPI-based transactions have become very common in India because of their convenience and speed. However, along with this growth, cybercrimes related to online payments have also increased. One of the most frequently reported issues is UPI fraud, where users are tricked into sending money unknowingly. This type of fraud mainly depends on manipulation rather than technical hacking.

How the Fraud Typically Happens

A common scenario begins when a fraudster contacts the victim through a phone call, SMS, WhatsApp, or even social media. They may pretend to be a bank official, customer support executive, or even a person interested in buying or selling something online.

First, the fraudster creates a sense of urgency. For example, they may say that the victim's bank account has a problem, or that a payment is pending and needs

immediate action. This makes the victim panic and act quickly without thinking carefully.

Next, the fraudster sends a payment request or a QR code, or asks the victim to click on a suspicious link. They may also guide the victim step-by-step on what to do, making it appear like a genuine process.

Then comes the most important trick — the victim is asked to enter their UPI PIN. Many people mistakenly believe that entering the PIN is required to receive money, but in reality, entering the PIN always authorizes sending money.

Within seconds, the amount gets transferred from the victim's account to the fraudster's account, and the fraudster disappears.

Who is Usually Targeted

This type of fraud mainly targets students, young users, and people who frequently use online payment apps. Since these users rely heavily on quick transactions, they may not always verify requests carefully. Sometimes even educated users fall victim due to pressure or confusion created by the fraudster.

Consequences of the Crime

The immediate consequence is financial loss, which can sometimes be significant. Apart from that, victims often feel stressed, embarrassed, or helpless after realizing they have been scammed. In some cases, it also leads to a loss of trust in digital payment systems.

Conclusion

UPI fraud is not just a technical issue but also a psychological one. It mainly works by creating fear, urgency, and confusion. Therefore, awareness and careful behavior are the best ways to prevent such cybercrimes. A small mistake can lead to major loss, so users must stay alert at all times.